Going Home

By Jason Sheets

NARRATOR: *All the world's a stage, and all the men and women merely players: they have their exits and their entrances; and one man in his time plays many parts"* **(Pgs 131-134)** Sometimes you laugh at yourself when you do it. After all, you have never even liked reading Shakespearean poetry. Still, every day from 9:00 until 10:00 in the morning you not only read it; you memorize it. You remember hearing that memorization keeps the mind active. You have given up on being physically active long ago, so you are making sure you can at least pride yourself on having a sound mind. You've heard all the jokes about it -- how you can meet new people every day and be able to hide your own Easter eggs. You have seen it happen to your friends. You have watched them slip away. You pray that you die before it happens to you.

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INTRODUCTION

A recent study of people over the age of 60 reports that the condition they are most afraid of is Alzheimer's. As people age, slight memory loss is normal; but Alzheimer's is an irreversible, progressive brain disease that slowly destroys memory, causes erratic behavior and robs a person of their personality.

For someone in the early stages, the experience can cause fear. Suddenly, they can't remember people they know or follow what others are saying. They can't remember why they went to the store and may get lost when they are . . .

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NARRATOR: Through the years, you have found that few things in life last as long as you'd hope they would, whether that be your eyesight, your friends, your teeth. This is what makes Mack special. He's been your golf partner and beer buddy since you finished law school 35 years ago. He definitely has not grown old gracefully. He dons a baseball cap inscribed with the words "Old Fart" on it and he golfs in these knickers that people constantly complement him on. Secretly, they laugh at him.

Bigger memories are starting to elude him now. He used to lose track of the time or forget his score on a

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golf hole. Now, he's lucky to remember his tee time. After he hits the ball he forgets where it went. He wanders down the fairway near the woods, desperately searching. When you direct him to his ball, he informs you that he doesn't need your help and walks in another direction. You ask him where he is going.

MACK: Home, I'm going home."

NARRATOR: You nod "goodbye" and watch him walk away. He'll return tomorrow.

You think of Mack when you open the books of Shakespeare the next morning. You thumb through the pages for a poem to memorize. *A short one today,* you tell yourself; *Jeopardy* comes on at 9:30. The poem reads: "Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?" You find this to be drivel, but you memorize it anyway. *It'll come in useful someday,* you tell yourself. Whenever people need a Bingo break you'll pipe out a few lines of ol' Billy Shakespeare and they'll all be stunned. Sure, it'll happen.

The word "Alzheimer's" is a part of your everyday vocabulary. It's your worst fear. Still, you have no clue when it

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begins to happen to you. Instead, you make excuses. You send your daughter's birthday card to your son's address. Damn address book. At the gas station, you forget the gas hose is still attached to your car and drive off, tearing the hose in two. Even as gas is flying everywhere, the station attendant says it happens all the time. You believe him.

You admit that you certainly don't have a problem compared to Mack. He doesn't leave the house anymore.

You forget your wife's anniversary and this really bothers you because you remember buying her a bracelet. Y

A phone surveyor asks you to vote for *[insert most recent candidate]* for president. Sorry, you say, but you still think *[insert most recent candidate]* will get your vote.

Nine a.m. frustrates you more than any part of the day. You've been memorizing the same poem for 3 months now. You peek at the book -- just to get started: "Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?" You have no clue what comes next. *It's that damn Old English,* you say, *it'll get you every time.*

You find your wife's anniversary bracelet. It has an

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inscription: "Happy Anniversary, *[insert year (3 years ago)]* " You look at the calendar: *[insert current year]*. You look at the clock: 9:30. Time for *Jeopardy*.

Photographs now hold a special meaning for you. You wish you had taken more of them. Snapshots of your father's hands. His smile. His jewelry. If you could actually take a picture of his laugh, you'd do that too.

Snapshots become a part of the daily schedule. They give you something that no one else can: instant memory. You look at them from 9:00 to 10:00 in the morning, during the hour you used to recite poetry. There was also some television show you used to watch, although you cannot recall its name. Whatever it was, it pales in comparison to the snapshots. Instant memory.

You feel as if the phone rings constantly. It always seems to be your son, Craig. He always asks the same question: "When are you going to come see your grandson?? Tyler needs to meet his grandfather. . . " What Craig fails to realize is that you have already tried to fly out to Seattle to see them once. You just couldn't find your way through the airport. Some places you can still navigate; you can

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find your way to church, to the park, to the store. Finding terminal B16 is a little beyond you at this point.

You will never go to Seattle; you'll never see Craig and Tyler; you'll never leave the neighborhood. At least you hope.

Three months later, you find that you are carrying a bag of groceries. Apparently, you have been to the store. It's autumn and the leaves are growing in technicolor. Yet, instead of looking at the vibrant autumn leaves, you are trying to find your way home. You find yourself walking on a baseball field. This isn't the way, but it does not occur to you. A man in his thirties in a Chicago Cubs baseball cap says,

MAN: Excuse me, sir. Are you lost??

NARRATOR: You are lost. You are desperately lost. "No."

MAN: Where do you live??

NARRATOR: I don't know.

MAN: Do you know your address?

NARRATOR: I don't know.

MAN: Is there someone I can call?

NARRATOR: You don't know. You just don't know. This man

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is firing questions at you like you are on . . . like you are on . . . like you're on *Jeopardy*.

MAN: Who are you?

NARRATOR: I don't know.

MAN: Where are you going?

NARRATOR: Home. I'm going home.

You're not dumb. You know you're in a nursing home. You know your son is talking to you.

CRAIG: See, this is your grandson, Tyler. Say 'hi' to your grandfather.

NARRATOR: You want to respond, to give your family some sort of acknowledgement, but words fail you again. What you feel and what you say are two different things. You want to say, "Hi, Tyler. I didn't used to be this way," but no words come out. You try to speak your thoughts through your eyes. You can't. Tyler is scared. He leaves.

You are left alone with Craig with nothing left to say. You look at him. He looks at you. He smiles and nods. He understands how much you care. You can close your eyes now. You are going home.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jason Sheets
Book: Turning Points, Pgs 131-134
ISBN: 978-0742117013
Publisher: Tichenor Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier - MS

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